UPSC Pods sell-first rework plan

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Your comments set one direction: sell with confidence, show off the variety, and give Plus a value prop the competition can't match. Below are the decisions I took from each comment, the work they add up to, and a priority list for you to rank.

Decisions from your comments

The big shift: honesty and calm stay in the product, but they stop being the headline. On welcome day we sell. The only lines I still hold are legal ones: we don't sell a feature that doesn't exist yet, and the crisis promise needs a real person behind it.

Where you commented	Your comment, in short	What I'll do
Verdict: CA test is free elsewhere	A fun, cinematic version beats a boring PDF	Turn the weekly CA test and monthly compilation into a cinematic recap (W7). Keep them as a Plus draw.
Verdict: "I'd stay for the community"	Hit back with a serious value prop: progress across mocks, where I'm getting lucky, where I'm stuck	Build Mock Intelligence as Plus's headline feature (W6).
E1: eight Prep sub-tabs	Rethink the interface. UI, copy and value props must come together	Redesign Prep and the first-run experience as one piece (W2).
E2: formats as plumbing	I missed the point. Show off the variety and the anti-boring content; traditional players can't	Withdrawn. Variety becomes a selling point: "one fact, seven ways to make it stick" (W2).
E3: Polity map only	Fine, but improve visibility	The syllabus is visible from the first Prep screen (W2).
E4: roadmap under Chotu	Let Chotu sell the whole thing, no hesitation, with a vibrant avatar and more animation	Chotu becomes the tour guide and salesperson (W1).
E5: next-steps never acted on	Find all such gaps and prioritise them	Listed under Gaps below.

Where you commented	Your comment, in short	What I'll do
"Games-and-news app"	Don't get defensive; use the moat and answer the feedback	Lead with what we do better: variety, speed of recall, pods, mock intelligence.
What to do: syllabus tree	Don't show completion to a visitor; lock it as Plus. Merge into the UI rework; fun and light	Free users see the syllabus and the content. Coverage tracking and the readiness view are Plus (W2, W6).
Pod E1: day 1 has no pod	Stop wearing honesty as a badge on welcome day. Think like a salesman	The first screens sell. The "not checked yet" labels move off the welcome path.
Pod E2: no unread counts	Anxiety has taken centre stage. We're not psychologists	Bring back unread counts and activity signals on Pod. The anti-anxiety filter is no longer a design veto.
Pod E3: ritual push	Do it smartly, using what the great authors say about rituals	Ritual nudge design below (W4).
Pod E4: AI friends	Remove the saintly veil and get to selling	Keep the AI study friends, still labelled AI. Drop "we never use fake members" from the copy, so we stop contradicting ourselves.
Pod E5: answer hour	Good, and sell it well	Answer posting and pod review become a headline feature (W5).
Pod What to do	Until 500 sign-ups, use pre-set open pods like Slack channels, by region, language, attempt and so on	Open pods until 500 sign-ups, then switch on matched pods (W3).
Eval E1: feedback quota	3 a week free until 500 sign-ups	Free: 3 evaluations a week until 500 sign-ups, then we review.
Eval E2: self-check rubric	Don't load onboarding with it; let Chotu ask on day 2	Onboarding stays short. Chotu asks the rubric and persona questions on day 2 and 3.
Eval E4: website claim	Be generous until 500 sign-ups	Same generous free tier. The claim stays once evaluation ships.

Where you commented	Your comment, in short	What I'll do
Eval E5: consumer-protection risk	List these and we'll evaluate priorities	Listed in W8, for you to rank.
Handwriting is speed practice	Do better: timers and focus mode while writing, track failed attempts, encourage writing	Answer Studio with timer, focus mode and an attempt log (W5).

Workstreams

Eight pieces of work. W2, W5 and W6 carry the sale; W1 and W3 get people to them.

W1. Chotu, tour guide and salesperson. A brighter, more animated Chotu: idle bob, wave, a steam puff when excited, eyes that follow taps. Chotu runs a 60-second guided tour on first open, shows each feature working, and ends with a confident Plus pitch and the founding price. Chotu brings Plus up again at moments of real value, like right after a mock result.

W2. Prep home rework. One screen that answers "is this real UPSC prep?" in 3 seconds.

- A syllabus strip at the top: Prelims, CSAT, GS1 to GS4, Essay and Ethics as tappable chips, each opening its topic tree.
- A "one fact, seven ways" showcase: today's topic as a flashcard, a trap spotter, a pair-up, a 30-second reel and a mnemonic, side by side. This is where the variety gets shown off.
- Today's 3 stays as a compact card.
- Down from eight sub-tabs to four: Today, Syllabus, Practice and Mocks, My Plan. Read and Learn go inside the syllabus nodes; Focus moves to the menu.
- Locked Plus layer on the syllabus: coverage %, revised ticks and the readiness meter show blurred with a Plus badge.
- A lighter, more playful tone in copy and motion.

W3. Open pods until 500 sign-ups. Pre-set rooms, like Slack channels, that anyone can join on day 1 and that are never empty:

- By language: Hindi medium, English medium, Telugu.
- By attempt: first attempt, repeaters, working aspirants.
- By goal: Prelims 2027 sprint, Mains answer writing, Optional rooms (PSIR, Sociology, Geography, Anthropology, History).
- By region: North, South, East and Northeast, West and Central.

Each room gets a pinned daily question, answer hour and quiz night, and the AI study friends keep it moving. At 500 sign-ups, matched 8-person pods switch on, and the rooms stay as the public layer.

W4. Ritual nudges. See the design below.

W5. Answer Studio.

- Write on paper with a visible timer: 7 minutes for 150 words, 11 for 250. Focus mode blocks other apps while the timer runs, reusing the Focus blocker.
- Snap a photo, get rubric feedback: directive word, structure, content, examples and data, conclusion, plus a model skeleton.
- An attempt log tracks finished, abandoned and over-time answers. Chotu encourages a comeback: "You started 3 and finished 1 this week. Let's finish one today, just 7 minutes."
- Send to pod for peer review in answer hour.
- Free tier: 3 evaluations a week until 500 sign-ups. Plus: unlimited.
- Rubric and persona questions come from Chotu on day 2, not during onboarding.

W6. Mock Intelligence, Plus's headline feature. What no one else shows:

- **Where you're getting lucky:** topics where you score but mark "not sure" or guess. Those marks won't hold on exam day.
- **Where you're stuck:** topics flat across your last 3 to 5 mocks despite study time.
- **Where you're losing marks to negative marking**, and your break-even guessing rate.
- **Surgical revision list:** the 10 syllabus nodes that move your score most this week, so you don't read the book from the preface a 95th time.
- A progress band across mocks, with a syllabus readiness map.

W7. Cinematic current affairs. The weekly CA test becomes a 5-minute "Week in 7 scenes": a narrated reel with sound beds, maps and the exam angle, then the quiz. The monthly compilation becomes a binge-able episode set rather than a PDF. It reuses the reels, radio and sound kit we already have. The first episode each week is free as a hook; the rest are Plus.

W8. Legal and trust exposure, for you to rank. These are legal risks, not ethics posture:

1. The website and Plus page claim answer feedback, which isn't built yet. W5 fixes it; until then the claim is a consumer-protection risk.
2. "PYQs by topic" is claimed, but the PYQ database is empty.
3. "Checked by a human editor" is claimed, but no editor is hired yet.
4. Payment through a WhatsApp number inside the Play app breaks Play billing policy and can get the app removed.

5. The legal entity on receipts is still a placeholder.
6. Cloud Chotu uses free AI tiers that may keep prompts. This needs a line in the privacy notice.
7. The copy promises a trained human moderator for distress, but the roster is empty.
8. "We never use fake members" contradicts the AI study friends. Removed under W3.

W4. Ritual nudges, designed from the research

Each ritual fires at a fixed weekly slot that becomes a habit, anchored to something the aspirant already does. The ideas come from our great-minds playbook (10 and 11 Oct). Selling is now allowed, so social proof and anticipation are in.

Ritual	When	Nudge copy (example)	Principle it borrows
Morning Chai	Daily, at the aspirant's own chai time	"Chai's ready. 3 cards, 4 minutes."	Fogg: anchor to an existing habit. Clear: habit stacking
Monday goal	Monday, 8 am	"Fresh week. Your room is setting goals: 23 in already."	Milkman: fresh-start effect. Oettingen: WOOP. Cialdini: honest social proof
Answer hour	Wed and Sat, 7 pm	"Answer hour in 15 min. Today's question is on federalism. Pen and paper ready?"	Gollwitzer: an if-then plan made on Monday. Duhigg: cue, routine, reward
Quiz night	Friday, 8 pm	"Quiz night: your room vs the Hindi-medium room. Starts at 8."	Anticipation plus friendly rivalry between rooms, not between people
Week in 7 scenes	Sunday, 10 am	"This week's CA in 7 scenes, 5 minutes. Episode 1 is free."	Heath: The Power of Moments. Temptation bundling (Milkman)
Comeback	After 3 quiet days	"Your room missed you. One 7-minute answer and you're back."	Fogg: make the start tiny. Clear: the two-minute rule

Smart rules:

- The aspirant picks their rituals during Chotu's day-2 chat, not during onboarding.

- At most 2 pushes a day. A ritual someone ignores 3 times drops to weekly, so it doesn't get muted.
- Each push opens straight into the action: the answer timer, the quiz lobby, the episode.
- No pushes after 22:30.
- Every ritual ends with a small reward moment: a room shout-out, a stamp, or Chotu's reaction.

Gaps we wrote down and never acted on

These come from `status/next-steps.md` (11 Oct) and the buyer review. Each was named as needed, and none is done as far as the project files show. Some may have moved on your PC without the notes being updated.

Gap	First written	Who can move it
Syllabus-deep material beyond Polity	11 Oct, next-steps	Claude drafts, editor approves
PYQ database (the file is empty)	11 Oct, next-steps	Claude
Editors for English, Hindi and Telugu (nothing is approved)	11 Oct, next-steps	You
First paid product chosen ("answer feedback plus study plan") but never built	11 Oct, next-steps	Claude, now W5 and W6
Push notifications for rituals	Android README	Claude, now W4
Full-length mocks beyond one sample paper	11 Oct, next-steps	Claude drafts
CSAT comprehension passages in mocks	Buyer review	Claude drafts
Business entity, GST and grievance officer (one lawyer call)	11 Oct, next-steps	You
Google Play developer account	11 Oct, next-steps	You
Signed release key	11 Oct, next-steps	You
Rotate the Cloudflare token and R2 keys	11 Oct, next-steps	You

Gap	First written	Who can move it
10 aspirant interviews	11 Oct, next-steps	You
Native-speaker check of Hindi and Telugu app text	11 Oct, next-steps	You find, Claude fixes
Crisis protocol sign-off and moderator roster	Community drafts	You
Privacy policy, terms, refund policy, AI disclosure	11 Oct, next-steps	Claude drafts, lawyer checks
Admin dashboard for the 5 core metrics	11 Oct, next-steps	Claude

Priority list for you to rank

The Priority column shows my suggestion. Change any dropdown and I'll re-sequence the build around it.

Item	Why this priority	Size	Priority
W5 Answer Studio: timer, focus mode, photo evaluation, attempt log	The #1 reason aspirants pay, and the website already promises it	L	P0 now
W2 Prep home rework, with the syllabus visible and the variety showcase	Answers "is this real prep?" in the first 3 seconds	M	P0 now
W1 Chotu tour and sales pitch, with the new animated avatar	Sells everything in the first minute	M	P0 now
W3 Open pods until 500 sign-ups	Day 1 always has a lively room	S	P0 now
Real checkout instead of WhatsApp, plus the legal entity	Play can remove the app over this	M	P0 now
Hire editors (English, Hindi, Telugu)	Nothing can go live unapproved	People	P0 now
Moderator roster before rooms open	The copy promises a human for distress	People	P0 now

Item	Why this priority	Size	Priority
W6 Mock Intelligence	Plus's headline, but it needs a few mocks per user first	M	P1 next
W4 Ritual nudges	Brings people back to the rooms	M	P1 next
W7 Cinematic current affairs	A fun, shareable reason to open the app weekly	M	P1 next
PYQ import, Prelims first	Table stakes, and the website claims it	M	P1 next
Privacy line on third-party AI	A one-paragraph legal fix	S	P1 next
Unread counts and activity signals on Pod	Reverses the old no-badge rule	S	P2 later

What has started

- [ ] **Build slice 1 on your PC** (running now, on a local branch only; nothing is deployed or pushed):
  - W3 open pods with the 500-sign-up switch.
  - Unread badges.
  - Removing the "no fake members" copy.
  - W5 Answer Studio: timer, focus mode, photo or typed answer, attempt log, send to pod, and the evaluation route with 3 free a week.
- [ ] **Next: design mocks for W1 and W2** (the Chotu tour and the Prep home), for your approval before any code.
- [ ] **After your ranking:** W6 Mock Intelligence, W4 ritual nudges, W7 cinematic CA.